Mayan script revealed how wrong many scholars were about the beliefs they had attributed to the Mayans (such as being peaceful).

The Harappans did not build monumental sculptures, such as of kings or gods, as did the Mesopotamians and the Egyptians. This doesn't make them any less complex than others, writes Possehl, rather it's an alternative way in which a civilization, with a 'highly complex sociocultural system, has expressed itself'.[26] They did make fine miniature art, as in seals and beadwork. And while their figurines aren't notable for their artisanship, they still evocatively depict their people 'in great variety, with many poses: sitting in chairs, lying on beds, holding babies and animals, kneading bread, and other things that people do to round out their existence,' writes Possehl. Animal puppets, in which a bull might shake its head or pull a cart, reveal a playful sense of humour, perhaps designed to amuse children. There are some fantasy creatures too, but 'on the whole, the Indus peoples in their art, as in other aspects of their lives, come across as people with a practical bent, a tendency to deal with and represent the real world as they [and we] see it'.[27]

That said, what jumps out as the Harappans' greatest monumental work is the city itself, a marvel of urban design and engineering, citywide sanitation systems that include the first indoor toilets in the world and sophisticated water management. 'Probably not until later Roman times did people devise so many clever construction techniques to deal with comforts and discomforts related to water.'[28] They also excelled at shipbuilding and long-distance trade—another reason to think that they had centralized authority and bureaucracy to mobilize labour, develop trading networks and organize long-distance shipping expeditions.